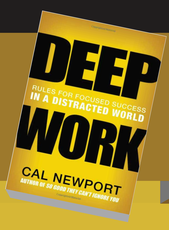
DEEP WORK

RULES FOR FOCUSED SUCCESS IN A DISTRACTED WORLD

Cal Newport



Deep Work = Focusing on cognitively-demanding tasks without distraction. It hones your skills, creates real value and is hard to replicate.

Shallow Work = Doing cognitively-undemanding tasks, often with distractions. It doesn't create much value and is easily replicated.

WHY DEEP WORK IS IMPORTANT

Deep work is Valuable

The economy increasingly values deep work.

Deep work is vital for high-impact activities e.g. writing a great novel, developing a winning strategy.

In the new economy where intelligent machines prevail, **you need 2 vital skills to thrive:** To master complex things quickly, and to apply the skills to create value. Working deeply for stretches of time steepens your learning, improves your cognitive capacity *and* performance.

By mastering the rare skills/abilities for deep work, you can improve your productivity, fulfillment and be much more valuable in the modern economy.

Deep work is Rare

We're increasingly moving toward a shallow work culture.

Constant digital distractions can be damaging: They reduce our effectiveness and may permanently reduce our capacity to focus deeply.

There're **3 business trends that hinder deep work** and increase distractions: Open offices, instant communication (e.g. emails, phone messages) and social media.

There're also **3 biases toward shallow work**: It's easier than deep work, busyness is used to measure productivity in the absence of clear work goals, and technology is assumed to be good by default.

Deep work can improve your Quality of Life

Deep work makes you happier and more fulfilled.

Neurological Perspective
It reinforces specific neural pathways to help you see your work as rich and fulfilling.

Psychological Perspective
It helps you get in "flow"—a state of enjoyable, energized focus.

Philosophical Perspective
It helps you to find meaning in perfecting a craft, not just doing a job.

RULES & STRATEGIES FOR DEEP WORK

Build Rituals and Routines

Build rituals and routines to overcome the obstacles to deep work and move easily into states of intense focus.

Tailor your approach to deep work

Options: Monastic (eliminate distractions), Bimodal (split between stretches of deep vs normal work), Rhythmic (daily rhythms for deep work), or Journalistic (fit in deep work whenever possible).

Build strict rituals

Define your ideal ritual—location, duration, rules and supporting elements—so you can transit smoothly into deep work.

Make grand gestures

Break your routine and invest a burst of time, money or effort—it refreshes you and commits you psychologically to the project.

Collaborate

You can jointly work on a problem with someone in a deep work session.

Execute effectively

Focus on 1 vital goal that excites you, act on lead measures that drive results, keep score and build a rhythm of accountability.

Go for downtime

Idle time is critical for productivity and insights. Have a shutdown ritual: put away all work issues at the end of the work day.

Train your Mind

Our mental muscles are strengthened with use. Train your mind to resist distractions and improve your capacity for intense focus.

Make focus the norm

Make focus your default mode of operation. Fix specific time blocks for distracting activities and avoid them outside of those time blocks.

Compress your timelines

Take a hard task, give yourself a shorter-than-usual timeline, then tackle it with intense focus.

Meditate productively

Use periods of time when you're occupied physically but not mentally (e.g. walking) to think deeply about a specific issue.

Do memory training

Memorize a deck of cards using Ron White's approach in the book or text summary.

Use Digital Media Selectively

Don't just use any tool that offers a benefit. Use only tools that bring a huge nett positive impact toward your goals.

Focus on the vital few

Evaluate every network tool. Use only top tools with a substantial nett positive impact on your goals.

Do a social media embargo

Stop using all social media for 30 days. Review if (i) the 30 days were noticeably worse and (ii) if people cared. Unless the answer is "yes" for both, drop the service.

Use leisure time wisely

Fill it with quality activities that enrich your mind. Don't use the internet for entertainment.

Limit Shallow Work

Take control of your shallow work, so they don't hijack your time/energy for deep work.

Schedule each day

Account for every minute: get better at estimating your time requirements and be deliberate about how you spend your time.

Quantify depth

Assess each activity in terms of how long it'd take for a fresh college grad to learn the task.

Set a quota

Define the % of time you should spend on shallow work. Stick to it.

Limit your work hours

Fix your desired work schedule, then set the rules and habits needed to complete your goals within the available time.

Take control of your emails

Set expectations on when you'll read/ respond to emails. Craft emails with the aim to close the loop in 1 email. Don't reply to emails that're ambiguous, irrelevant or have no impact.